
IM0802 – Responsible Artificial Intelligence

Assignment 2: “Paper Title Goes Here”

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Abstract

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1 Introduction 350

Israel, which allocates 8.8% of its GDP to defense [1], invests heavily in the development of autonomous weapon systems (AWS), with their Prime Minister announcing a \$100 billion investment in homegrown arms production last December [2]. Israel’s most well-known AWS is the Iron Dome air defense system, which intercepts incoming projectiles in real time. Building on this foundation in artificial intelligence (AI)-assisted defense technology, Israel has expanded into offensive targeting applications such as “Habsora”.

Habsora ("The Gospel") is an Israeli Defense Forces (IDF) AI-targeting system developed primarily by Unit 8200 within the Military Intelligence Directorate. First deployed during the May 2021 Operation "Guardian of the Walls", it generates target recommendations using a multimodal intelligence pipeline that encompasses signal intelligence, telephone metadata, satellite and drone imagery, social graph analysis, and life-pattern modelling [3, 4]. The system is not a single model, but an ensemble of multiple specialised algorithms fused together [4]. During the 2023-2024 Gaza conflict, Habsora was reported to generate over one hundred target recommendations per day, which in prior years required approximately twelve months of human analysts [3, 5].

Habsora’s AI capability is the probabilistic classification and prioritisation of locations and individuals as military objectives. It assigns confidence scores derived from large-scale pattern matching across a shared intelligence pool, rather than positive identification in the traditional intelligence analysis [6]. Military commands nominally authorise each recommendation, yet their review window documented for each target was approximately twenty seconds [3].

This creates a stakeholder dynamic with both ethical and legal significance. It’s output influencing both IDF commands, who operate under high cognitive load and time pressure; Palestinian civilians in the target environment bearing the lethal consequences and the broader international community which depends on International Humanitarian Law (IHL) compliance for the legitimacy of armed conflict. Steen et al. [7] offer a framework for this tension. They propose a two-axis model of Meaningful Human Control (MHC) which distinguishes between high automation and genuine human control, which both require adequate information and real freedom of action. The central argument of this report is that Habsora structurally undermines the second condition, and that this gap carries cascading implications across the technical, sociotechnical, and governance layers identified by Verdiesen et al. [8] in their Comprehensive Human Oversight Framework (CHOF).

2 Ethical Issue Identification 750

The CHOF structures oversight across three layers: governance, socio-technical layer, and technical. Each of these layers is further analysed across three temporal phases: before, during, and after deployment of the autonomous weapon system. The governance layer concerns the legal and ethical conditions, investigating whether societal values and ethical principles are respected. The socio-technical layer focuses on the stakeholders involved, both the ones operating the system and those personally affected by it. The technical layer looks at the system itself, addressing issues such as automation bias and the system working as a black box, meaning the inner workings of the system are not transparent to users or stakeholders. Underpinning all three layers is the Glass Box approach described by Aler Tubella et al. [9]. This approach translates abstract values, such as human dignity, into observable norms and requirements to be implemented in the the AI system.

2.1 Governance Layer

- Compliance with International Humanitarian Law (IHL), particularly the principles of distinction, proportionality, and precaution
- Accountability gaps: who is legally responsible when an AI system recommends a target
- Lack of international regulatory frameworks governing offensive AI in armed conflict
- Whether existing rules of engagement adequately account for AI-generated targeting recommendations

2.2 Socio-technical Layer

- The role of IDF commanders as operators under high cognitive load and time pressure
- Automation bias and its effect on genuine human control over targeting decisions
- The position of Palestinian civilians as non-consenting stakeholders bearing the consequences
- Erosion of meaningful human control as defined by Steen et al.

2.3 Technical Layer

- Opacity of the system: lack of explainability in target recommendations
- Reliability and error rates, and how these propagate into lethal decisions
- Absence of observable, verifiable requirements as demanded by the Glass Box approach
- Speed of output generation and its incompatibility with meaningful human review

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